North of the Arctic Circle

The road narrowed as it followed the fjord. By the time we reached the last bend, the clouds had dropped low enough to hide the mountains, leaving just the water and a white house on the shore. We stopped the car, turned off the engine, and listened to nothing at all for a long while.

Senja is often described as *Norway in miniature*, a phrase that sounds like a brochure until you drive across it in a single afternoon and pass through farmland, birch forest, bare granite, and a coastline that looks as if it had been torn rather than cut. The island sits off the coast of Troms, connected to the mainland by a bridge at Gisund, and most visitors arrive the way we did: late, tired, and slightly unprepared for how quickly the light changes.

ARRIVAL

We had booked a cottage in Mefjordvær for five nights. The owner had sent instructions in a long email that ended with a sentence we only understood later: **the key is under the stone that does not belong there.** It took us twenty minutes and a torch to find it, and when we did, the stone was obviously, almost comically, out of place — a smooth grey pebble from a river beach sitting among the sharp fragments of the slope.

Inside, the cottage smelled of pine and old coffee. The windows faced north, which in September means the sun never shines directly into the rooms, but the reflected light from the water fills them with a cool, even brightness that photographers spend whole careers trying to reproduce in a studio. We unpacked, ate bread and brown cheese standing at the counter, and went to bed before ten.

Notes from the first evening

- Wind from the west, steady, cold enough for gloves.
- Tide low at about seven; the slate shelf below the house exposed for perhaps a hundred metres.
- Three sea eagles over the mouth of the fjord, one of them carrying something that was probably a fish and possibly a small gull.
- A fishing boat named *Senjaværing* returning at dusk, followed by a cloud of birds so dense it looked like smoke.

ALONG THE RIDGE

The hike to Segla is short on the map and long in the legs. The trail climbs almost directly from the road, through a band of stunted birch and then onto open rock, and the final section follows a ridge with a drop on the left side that is best not looked at for too long. We started early, partly to avoid other walkers and partly because the forecast promised rain by the afternoon.

The route, as we noted it on the way down:

1. Park at the small lot by the road to Fjordgård and follow the marked path uphill.
2. After the birch forest, keep left at the cairn where the path to Hesten branches off.
3. Cross the boulder field slowly; the stones move more than they appear to.
4. Join the ridge at the saddle and follow it north. This section is exposed, and in wet conditions the rock is slippery enough that we would not recommend it.
5. The summit is a narrow platform with room for perhaps six people standing close together.
6. Return the same way. The descent took us almost as long as the climb, mostly because we kept stopping to photograph the light moving across Mefjorden.
7. Eat something at the saddle, even if you are not hungry.
8. Check the weather again before the boulder field; conditions on the ridge change within minutes.
9. Leave nothing behind, including orange peel, which takes years to decompose in this climate.
10. Sign the summit book if it is still there; ours was the four hundred and twelfth entry of the season.
11. Watch for reindeer on the lower slopes in the evening.
12. Expect to be tired, and expect the view to be worth it.

> *The mountains here do not rise gradually. They stand up out of the sea as if they had been placed there afterwards, and the sea has not yet decided whether to accept them.*
>
> *— from a guidebook we found in the cottage, author unknown*

The rain arrived exactly when the forecast said it would. We were already back at the car, eating the last of the bread, watching the summit disappear into cloud.

THE QUIET COAST

On the fourth day we drove west along the outer coast, stopping wherever there was room to pull over. The road here is a sequence of tunnels and short bridges, each opening onto a different bay, and after a while the bays begin to blur together in memory: white sand, green water, a red boathouse, a mountain behind. Only the photographs keep them apart.

At Ersfjord there is a small public toilet with a golden roof, which every guidebook mentions and which turns out to be exactly as strange as it sounds. At Tungeneset a wooden walkway leads out over the rocks to a viewpoint facing the jagged line of Okshornan, the peaks that appear on almost every postcard of the island. We arrived just as a bus unloaded forty people, and left ten minutes later when the light went flat.

For anyone planning a similar trip, the most useful resource we found was the regional road status page at https://www.vegvesen.no/trafikk/hvaskjer?lat=69.3&lon=17.3&zoom=9&type=road-closures-and-ferry-information-for-troms, which lists closures, ferry changes, and tunnel works far more reliably than any map application.

What we would do differently

- Stay longer in one place rather than moving between cottages.
- Bring a second pair of boots; one pair never dried.
- Learn the names of the birds before going, not after.
  - Especially the difference between a white-tailed eagle and a golden eagle, which is obvious in a book and almost impossible at a distance.
  - And the various gulls, which we gave up on entirely.
- Leave the drone at home. Nobody needs another aerial photograph of Bergsbotn.

LEAVING

On the last morning the clouds lifted for the first time in three days. The mountains across the fjord came out one by one, as if someone

were slowly drawing back a curtain, and by nine o'clock the whole range was visible, sharp and close and covered in the first snow of the season. We loaded the car and drove away, and neither of us said very much until we reached the bridge.

Part two

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